The 2025 M&S Cyberattack: Trust, Access, Recovery

CS50's Introduction to Cybersecurity: Final Project

Presenter	Zunera Amber R
edX username	zunera_7
GitHub username	ambercodes20
Date recorded	25 October 2026
Incident	Marks & Spencer (M&S) cyberattack, April 2025
CVE	None applicable (no specific software vulnerability was identified)
Video	[Add your unlisted YouTube link here]

Overview

This project is a narrated slideshow (about 8 minutes 43 seconds) analyzing the April 2025 cyberattack on the UK retailer Marks & Spencer. It looks at the incident through three ideas:

- **Trust:** the attackers used social engineering, and entered through a third party.
- **Access:** how one compromised identity can expose many systems, and why least privilege matters.
- **Recovery:** how the company responded, and what good incident response looks like.

The presentation separates what is **confirmed by M&S** from what is only **reported by the media**, and labels any analysis of my own as analysis.

Link to the course

The project connects to these CS50 Cybersecurity topics:

- Social engineering
- Authentication and multi-factor authentication (MFA)
- Access control and least privilege
- Ransomware and incident response
- Confidentiality, integrity and availability (CIA triad)

- Privacy and data protection

Slide outline

1. Title and identification
2. Executive summary
3. Incident timeline
4. Trust: social engineering as the entry point
5. Access: attack-chain analysis
6. Impact on the CIA triad
7. Business and customer impact
8. Recovery: documented response vs best practice
9. Risk-to-control mapping
10. Lessons for software and data engineers
11. Conclusion
12. References

Repository contents

- `MS_Cyberattack_Final_Project_v5.pptx` : the slides
- `Narration_Script_v2.md` : the narration script used for the voiceover
- `README.md` : this file

Sources

1. Marks & Spencer, "Cyber Incident - Further Update", 23 April 2025. https://corporate.marksandspencer.com/newsroom/press-releases/cyber-incident-further-update
2. Marks & Spencer (RNS), "Cyber Incident - Further Update", 13 May 2025. https://www.investegate.co.uk/announcement/rns/marks-spencer-group--mks/cyber-incident-further-update-/8874910
3. UK Information Commissioner's Office, "Statement on cyber incidents impacting retailers", 2 May 2025. https://ico.org.uk/about-the-ico/media-centre/news-and-blogs/2025/05/statement-on-cyber-incidents-impacting-retailers/
4. Reuters, "M&S says cyber hackers broke in through third-party contractor", 21 May 2025. https://www.investing.com/news/stock-market-news/ms-says-hackers-broke-in-through-thirdparty-contractor-4056748
5. ManageEngine, "Marks & Spencer ransomware attack: Cybersecurity lessons for the retail sector" (summarises BleepingComputer, 5 May 2025).

https://www.manageengine.com/log-management/cyber-security/marks-and-spencer-ransomware-retail-sector-cybersecurity.html

Notes

- Some technical details of the attack (such as the exact impersonation method and the attackers' identity) are based on media reports and have not been confirmed by M&S. The slides label these clearly.
- The voiceover was generated with an AI text-to-speech tool, which the course allows. Generative AI was also used as a research and drafting aid.
- This is a student project for educational purposes. It is not affiliated with, or endorsed by, Marks & Spencer or Harvard.